Rugged Individualism

Herbert Hoover · campaign speech · New York City · October 22, 1928 · excerpts

Source: Hoover Presidential Library; reprinted in The New Day (1928).

Two weeks before he won the presidency, Hoover gave his major economic-philosophy speech at Madison Square Garden. He contrasted American 'rugged individualism' with what he saw as the European tradition of state paternalism. The speech aged badly: less than a year later the Great Depression began, and Hoover's reluctance to use federal power to address it became the central liability of his presidency.

Connect: Hoover's laissez-faire approach in 1929-33 was consistent with Republican philosophy since McKinley. What broke this consensus by 1932?

Key Passages

On American distinctiveness

> When the war closed, the most vital of all issues both in our own country and throughout the world was whether governments should continue their wartime ownership and operation of many instrumentalities of production and distribution. … We were challenged with a peace-time choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines — doctrines of paternalism and state socialism.

On government and business

> We are nearer today to the ideal of the abolition of poverty and fear from the lives of men and women than ever before in any land. … Through liberation from widespread poverty we have reached a higher degree of individual freedom than ever before.

On equality of opportunity

> It is, in fact, our system of opportunity, our system of which has given us our wealth and our individual freedom.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HIPP for 3 docs (1 pt): Practice writing one sentence each of Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for Hoover's speech.

2. Identify ONE specific 1930s policy Hoover would have called 'state paternalism.'

3. How does this speech's framing of poverty differ from FDR's First Inaugural five years later?